Eva Smith

Eva Smith is absent from stage and from the play but has a powerful presence in the lives of the Birlings. Priestley represents the masses of poor, working class people through Eva. Eva embodies the voiceless and faceless poor and oppressed people of England at the time the play was set. Eva is described in an **idealized way** – innocent victim, pretty, a good worker. She is presented as a symbol of the working class woman. In some ways, Priestley presents her as a martyr. The lower she sinks in her fortunes, the more honourable and noble she appears. She refuses to treat others as they have treated her, even though she is in a position to create scandal for them all. Through Eva Smith, Eva represents ordinary people who can be destroyed when society fails to grant them the right of basic human dignity. When Eric says '**the one I knew is dead,'** we get the impression that he feels responsible and guilty about his conduct and carelessness**.** Through the other characters like Eric, we recognise that Eva was overlooked because of her social status
Her connection to the characters in the play is what prompts their confessions. Through Eva, Priestley promotes the idea that we have collective social responsibility. Despite her lower social class and death, Eva could be said to have the upper hand in the play as she is the one who has revealed the secrets of the Birlings and the Crofts and injustices she was subjected to. Mr Birling says **'Rubbish! If you don't come down sharply on some of these people , they'de be asking for the earth.'** Clearly Mr Birling, who represents all other middle- class people believe that workers do not have the right to demand for fair wages and working conditions. Since Inspector Goole is Priestley's mouth piece and promotes collective responsibility, he reminds the Birlings that '**it is better to ask for the earth, than take it'**

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Timeline of Events that led to Eva's death

September 1910 Eva sacked by Birling & Co.

December 1910 Eva employed by Milwards.

Late January 1911 Eva sacked by Milwards.

March 1911 Eva becomes Gerald's mistress.

Early September 1911 Gerald breaks off the affair.

Eva leaves Brumley for two months.

November 1911 Eric meets Eva.

December 1911/January 1912 Eva finds she is pregnant.

Late March 1912 Mrs. Birling turns down Eva's application for

Early April 1912 Eva's suicide/the Inspector calls

Key Quotes

'Now – about this girl, Eva Smith. I remember her quite well now. She was a lively good-looking girl – country-bred, I fancy – and she'd been working in one of our shops for over a year. A good worker too."

"…and died, after several hours of agony…"

"She was a very pretty girl…that didn't make it any better."

"She was young and pretty and warm-hearted- and intensely grateful. I became at once the most important person in her life- you understand?"

"She was giving herself ridiculous airs…claiming elaborate fine feelings…that were simply absurd in a girl in her position."

"As if a girl of that sort would ever refuse money!"

Themes

Social Class
Social Responsibility
Class Division
Gender Inequality

How does Priestley present the character of Eva Smith ideas about social responsibility in the play?

Think about:

- *What are Priestley's views? What and who does Eva represent in the play?*
- *How is she treated and what does this suggest about society and attitudes of people at that time?*
- *How does Priestley convey his views through the characters thoughts, words and behaviour and their treatment of Eva Smith?*

Your answer must include:

AO1 *(Your understanding and interpretation of Eva Smith in relation to the other characters, the themes and quotations)*

AO2 *(Identify and Explain the Language devices and Stage directions that convey ideas about Eva and Priestley's views)*

AO3 *(Context – Ideas about the historical, political and social background)*

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